independence the Western educated Pakistani elites were concerned with the creation of a state with a Muslim majority free from Hindu rule – yet not an Islamic state: 'The westernised leadership was modern and therefore capable of creating a viable state, but it was not religious and therefore incapable of creating an Islamic state' (Islam 1981, p. 58). During the Ayub era (1958–67) the military and bureaucratic elite shifted the focus from religion to economic growth, using 'bureaucratic mechanisms rather than ideological-political means for national integration' (Islam 1981, p. 59). Bhutto (1971–77) developed 'Islamic socialism' with a stress on popular conceptions of Islam. It was under General Zia that Islam was increasingly seen as a central tenet of Pakistani national identity, and religion became a means by which Pakistan not only justified its existence, but also used it as a tool for domestic unity as well as against perceived external threats such as India. Zia's policy of Islamization through the introduction of Islamic norms and laws radicalized Pakistani society between 1977 and 1988.[6] Sunni Islam became a central tenet of Pakistani identity. To the great consternation of Sunni communities, the introduction of Zakat and the Iranian revolution led to a radicalization of the Shi'a identity. This in turn also led to Sunni religious nationalism, especially among the Sunni urban middle classes, who were often Mohajirs, or the new middle class in the Punjab which grew due to the increased Gulf labour remittances of the 1970s. Radical sectarianism increasingly supported by the middle classes started to flourish and has over the years led to much bloodshed and the creation of radical sectarian groups such as the Sipah-e-Sahaba Pakistan (SSP) whose aim is to have Shi'as declared 'non-Muslim' under the Pakistani constitution. Zia's legacy of sectarian division as well as an Islamic curriculum across all state schools still affect society today.

From independence onwards issues of citizenship were confused with those of national identity. With national identity being so closely linked to religion it has meant that to this day all three concepts are often mixed up. The fact that national identity – and with it the role of religion – is only one tenet of citizenship has generally been lost. The 'other side' of citizenship, that is, rights and responsibilities and so on, has become a problem. Dean has argued that Pakistani children are not equipped at school with the tools to become participative citizens: '[W]hile Pakistani students acquire knowledge and learn some important values in school, they do not learn the skills (problem-solving, decision-making) and values (civic mindedness, critical consciousness) required for effective participation in democratic life' (Dean 2005, p. 35). Dean's study on citizenship in Pakistan showed that 'the organization and management of schools and most teaching and learning practices are not conducive to the